

Design Thinking

Part of **UI/UX Design Principles** · Estimated time: 30 min

Introduction

Design thinking is a way of working that puts the person using a product ahead of the features on a spec sheet. It's less a rigid process than a habit of checking your assumptions against real people before committing to a solution.

Core ideas

- The five commonly cited stages are: empathize (understand the user's real situation), define (frame the actual problem), ideate (generate many possible solutions), prototype (make a rough version), and test (see how real people respond).
- A well-framed problem statement focuses on the user's need, not a specific solution — "commuters need to know when the next bus arrives" rather than "we need an app."
- The stages aren't strictly linear — testing often sends you back to redefine the problem once you see how people actually behave.
- Cheap, early prototypes (paper, sketches) are meant to be thrown away; that's what makes them useful for testing ideas fast.

Try it yourself

Pick an everyday frustration (e.g. finding parking, splitting a bill with friends). Write a one-sentence problem statement focused on the user's need, not a solution, then list three completely different ways you might solve it.

Further reading

- Nielsen Norman Group — Design Thinking 101

<https://www.nngroup.com/articles/design-thinking/>

- Interaction Design Foundation — What is Design Thinking?

<https://www.interaction-design.org/literature/topics/design-thinking>

ModuloTrainer reading material — return to the app to mark this module complete.